

Session 19: Resting in God’s Provision

Key Takeaways

- The Sabbath command is a blessing of God’s rest for every person and animal in the nation.
- Heads of the household are responsible for ensuring that everyone has the opportunity to rest.
- God himself rests on the seventh day of creation. He also destroys the oppression that forces humans into endless slave labor, and both of these realities become reasons for the Sabbath command.

The Sabbath Command

Exodus 20:8-11 NIV

⁸ Remember the Sabbath day by keeping it holy. ⁹ Six days you shall labor and do all your work, ¹⁰ but the seventh day is a sabbath to the LORD your God. On it you shall not do any work, neither you, nor your son or daughter, nor your male or female servant, nor your animals, nor any foreigner residing in your towns. ¹¹ For in six days the LORD made the heavens and the earth, the sea, and all that is in them, but he rested on the seventh day. Therefore the LORD blessed the Sabbath day and made it holy.

Pay close attention how this command is phrased. What is the Sabbath for? It’s a day of rest and stopping. Who is the Sabbath for? It is for everyone in the community—rich or poor, native-born or foreigner, male or female, human or animal. Everyone gets a rest.

Finally, why should we keep the Sabbath? It’s because God set this pattern at creation when he finished his work and rested.

A Tale of Two Sabbaths

Notice that when this command is repeated in Deuteronomy the reason for keeping the Sabbath shifts focus.

Exodus 20:8-11	Deuteronomy 5:12-15
⁸ "Remember the Sabbath day by keeping it holy.	¹² "Observe the Sabbath day by keeping it holy, as the LORD your God has commanded you .
Comparing the Sabbath Commands. Created by Carmen Imes for BibleProject Classroom: Exodus Overview (2021).	

Exodus 20:8-11

⁹ Six days you shall labor and do all your work,
¹⁰ but the seventh day is a sabbath to the LORD your God. On it you shall not do any work, neither you, nor your son or daughter, nor your male or female servant, nor your animals, nor any foreigner residing in your towns.

¹¹ **For in six days the LORD made the heavens and the earth, the sea, and all that is in them, but he rested on the seventh day .**

Therefore the LORD **blessed the Sabbath day and made it holy .**

Deuteronomy 5:12-15

¹³ Six days you shall labor and do all your work,
¹⁴ but the seventh day is a sabbath to the LORD your God. On it you shall not do any work, neither you, nor your son or daughter, nor your male or female servant, nor **your ox, your donkey or any of your animals** , nor any foreigner residing in your towns, **so that your male and female servants may rest, as you do .**

¹⁵ **Remember that you were slaves in Egypt and that the LORD your God brought you out of there with a mighty hand and an outstretched arm .**

Therefore the LORD **your God** **has commanded you to observe the Sabbath day .**

Comparing the Sabbath Commands. Created by Carmen Imes for BibleProject Classroom: Exodus Overview (2021).

The Sabbath command is rooted in the pattern of creation, the memory of enslavement, and God's desire for humans to live free from oppression.

Reflection Question

In what ways does the command to "remember the Sabbath day" connect to the biblical story so far?